

Tables of Ambition

Chapter 1: The Elevator Rush

The elevator doors slid open with a whisper, releasing Laura into the hushed realm of Alo. 163 Spadina Avenue, third floor — a hidden sanctuary above Toronto’s bustling street, where Patrick Kriss’s contemporary French-Asian tasting menu had earned its one Michelin star in 2022 and held it through relentless elegance. At twenty-two, Laura felt the weight of her tray like a test of fate: two flutes of Veuve Clicquot Brut, chilled to perfection, rims sparkling under the soft, diffused lighting. Her first fine dining shift, nerves electric, ambition burning brighter than the ambient glow.

She’d come from suburb chain diners, where spills were shrugged off with a mop and a curse, but here? Alo demanded precision. The dining room unfolded — modern minimalism, tables spaced for intimacy, every detail curated. Rush hour buzzed: servers gliding like shadows, guests in tailored suits savoring the unexpected.

Step, pivot left toward Table 12. Anniversary couple, mid-40s, her necklace catching light. Celebrity aura (Neil Patrick echo). Tray tilt — physics rebelled, wine arc.

Instinct ServeMaster: weight forward, grip loose. Pivot smooth. No spill.

Flutes placed clockwise right, twist finish, wipe unseen. “I heard celebrating — happy smooth,” natural.

Relief. Grit grace.

Kensington motel reflection: practice before.

Tray drill mirror: ServeMaster seed.

Tomorrow more.

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